Similarly, when Arunachal Pradesh's Chief Minister met the Dalai Lama in early October the same year, they planned a visit by the Dalai Lama to Tawang for March 2017. Again, China reacted. The Chinese foreign ministry argued that the visit could affect border peace and stability and damage bilateral ties. The Dalai Lama's activities were characterised as anti-China separatism.[55] India, on its side, argued that the Dalai Lama was an honoured guest of India, free to travel to any part of the country. As the press noted, in diplomatic relations, language is of paramount importance. The Chinese reference to "peace and tranquillity in the border region" was not likely coincidental, this being the title of the 1993 agreement between India and China by which the two countries committed themselves to peace along the border.[56]

Following the military stand-off at Doklam in June 2017, the Modi government toned down its support for the Tibetan leader and diaspora. In March 2018, India banned a rally with the Dalai Lama which the Tibetan community wanted to stage in New Delhi to mark the 60th anniversary of the uprising against China.[57] Furthermore, following the visit of India's Foreign Secretary Vijay Gokhale to Beijing in February 2018, officials in New Delhi were reportedly instructed to reduce their contacts with the Tibetan diaspora.[58]

China and the India–Pakistan border

Events on the India–Pakistan border also illustrate the importance of the India–China–Pakistan triangle and its effect on Sino–Indian relations. In January 2016, an armed group suspected to belong to the Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammed attacked the Pathankot Air Force station, causing the death of seven Indian soldiers. In September